



## DEFIANT: Musharraf (R) stands firm as Sharif leaves in tears

The end result of these events, however, is that Sharif is ostensibly out of Musharraf's hair for the foreseeable future. And while the Government's actions have been met with widespread condemnation, the expected street protests have failed to materialise. Even the call for protests on September 11—given by the All Parties Democratic Movement (APDM) formed recently in London by Sharif comprising most Opposition parties other than Benazir Bhutto's Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP)—was a tepid affair.

Analysts believe part of the reason for the lukewarm political response to Sharif's return—only a couple of thousand activists were arrested trying to get to the airport—may have had to do with the other parties within the APDM not wanting to bolster Sharif's position before the general elections due within the next few months.

But, assuming that the assessment of a rise in Sharif's popularity is correct, part of the lukewarm response was also due to the lack of organisational skills of his own party

cadres. This is a damning indictment of Pakistani politicians, who are riding more on the back of popular support for the lawyers' movement against Musharraf than on their own political work.

Whatever the case may be, Sharif's removal from the scene gives more space to Bhutto to finalise a deal with Musharraf that would allow the General to remain in power. Musharraf may have got some breathing space for now but he is not out of the woods yet. Should such a deal fail, he may be left with very few options. He will not have the requisite votes to bring about a constitutional amendment allowing him to be re-elected president from the current Parliament, and relying on a new parliament after general elections may be too big a gamble to take.

An adverse judgment from the Supreme Court regarding Sharif's deportation could be the last straw. In such a stand-off between the Presidency and the judiciary, imposing martial law may be the only option for the army. Where that takes Pakistan is anybody's guess. ■



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